CHRIS **HICKMAN**

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SUMMARY

Backend engineer with 3+ years shipping production systems at Walmart scale, including agentic AI features for Sparky: Walmart's AI shopping assistant serving 1M+ monthly customers. Specialized in Java/Spring Boot microservices, distributed systems, and Kafka. Proven track record of owning features end-to-end from design through production, with measurable revenue impact. Open to backend or full-stack roles.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

LANGUAGES

- Java (8, 11,17,21)
- Kotlin
- Python
- JavaScript

BACKEND:

- Spring Boot
- Kafka
- REST APIs
- Microservices

FRONTEND:

- React
- HTML
- CSS

MONITORING:

- Grafana
- Splunk

DEVOPS:

- CI/CD
- Kubernetes
- Jenkins
- Maven, Gradle

CLOUD AND DATA:

- Azure CosmosDB
- GCP (BigQuery, AlloyDB)
- PostgreSQL

SOFTWARE & DESIGN TOOLS:

- IntelliJ IDEA
- Postman
- Git

EXPERIENCE

APRIL 2025 – PRESENT

SOFTWARE ENGINEER – SPARKY AI WALMART EMERGING TECH, HOBOKEN NJ

Backend engineer on Walmart's agentic AI shopping assistant, owning features end-to-end across design, implementation, and production release in a high-velocity Java 21/Spring Boot environment.

- Led end-to-end engineering for the **Essentials Experience**, driving increased GMV and improved customer access to high-frequency everyday items across Sparky's agentic product discovery flow.
- Owned and delivered **Sparky Ads integration**, inheriting established contracts and driving implementation to completion- enabling monetized AI-driven product recommendations and generating meaningful incremental revenue through partner brand placements
- Drove **engineering excellence initiatives** focused on scalable microservice architecture, maintainability, and production readiness in an ecommerce environment used by over 1M+ monthly customers.

FEBRUARY 2023 – APRIL 2025

SOFTWARE ENGINEER – CATALOG WALMART GLOBAL TECH, HOBOKEN NJ

Enhanced and maintained Walmart's product setup pipeline, ensuring accurate product matching and catalog integrity. Built and optimized scalable, high-performance systems critical to product setup, including Matching and Normalization.

- **Designed and optimized RESTful APIs**, improving data retrieval efficiency and system reliability. Modernized mission-critical Product Merge and Split APIs, by leading a zero-downtime migration from Java 8 to Java 21. Leveraged Spring Boot 3.x and Virtual Threads to optimize concurrency, resulting in a 40% reduction in p99 latency for high-volume catalog transactions.
- **Built and maintained Kafka-based microservices**, streamlining product data processing and reducing consumer lag.
- **Designed Spark jobs in PySpark**, processing millions of messages from Kafka and integrating with GCP storage solutions.
- **Led improvements in product matching systems**, enhancing data normalization and catalog accuracy for billions of products.

EDUCATION

2019 – 2022

BS COMPUTER SCIENCE, CLARKSON UNIVERSITY POTSDAM, NY

Strong foundation in algorithms, software design, and OOP (Java, C++). Graduated with great distinction, GPA: 3.86

AAS GRAPHIC ART AND DESIGN, NCCC

Mastered design principles, UI/UX concepts, and the Adobe Suite.